

Text vs Object, Naples March 2017

Christopher Nuttall

Uppsala University

*Investigating culture
without text?
Prehistoric maritime
culture in the Aegean in
the absence of textual
evidence*



Overview

- PhD Topic overview
- Seascape perspective
- Material Engagement Theory
- The human mind
- Material culture/Representation like text



PhD topic

- Cultural responses to living in a seascape
- Underlying assumptions about maritime communities in previous research
- Aegean littoral is a marginal area, with better alternatives for subsistence elsewhere
- Social determinism



Questions

- How did Aegean prehistoric maritime communities (4000 BC – 1600 BC) construct their world and interact with it?
- How this was manifested in cultural practices? (i.e. material culture, mortuary, culinary practices)
- “Life and death in the Aegean seascape”



What is a seascape?

Seascape perspective

- Seascape perspective a dominant paradigm in investigation of maritime culture
- Sea an active constituent of maritime societies
- Source of economic, political, symbolic significance
- Significance of the sea is culturally negotiated
- Aegean is a fruitful area

“blanketed with history and imbued with names, myths and legends”
Cordell 1989



“A maritime way of life may be an obvious option, but it is neither the only nor an inevitable one in the Aegean. There is always room for choice in the relation between people and the sea and this relation may acquire various forms and different degrees of intimacy”

Vavouranakis 2011

"combination of sensory registers... derived from practical experience in a particular place and time“

Rainbird 2007

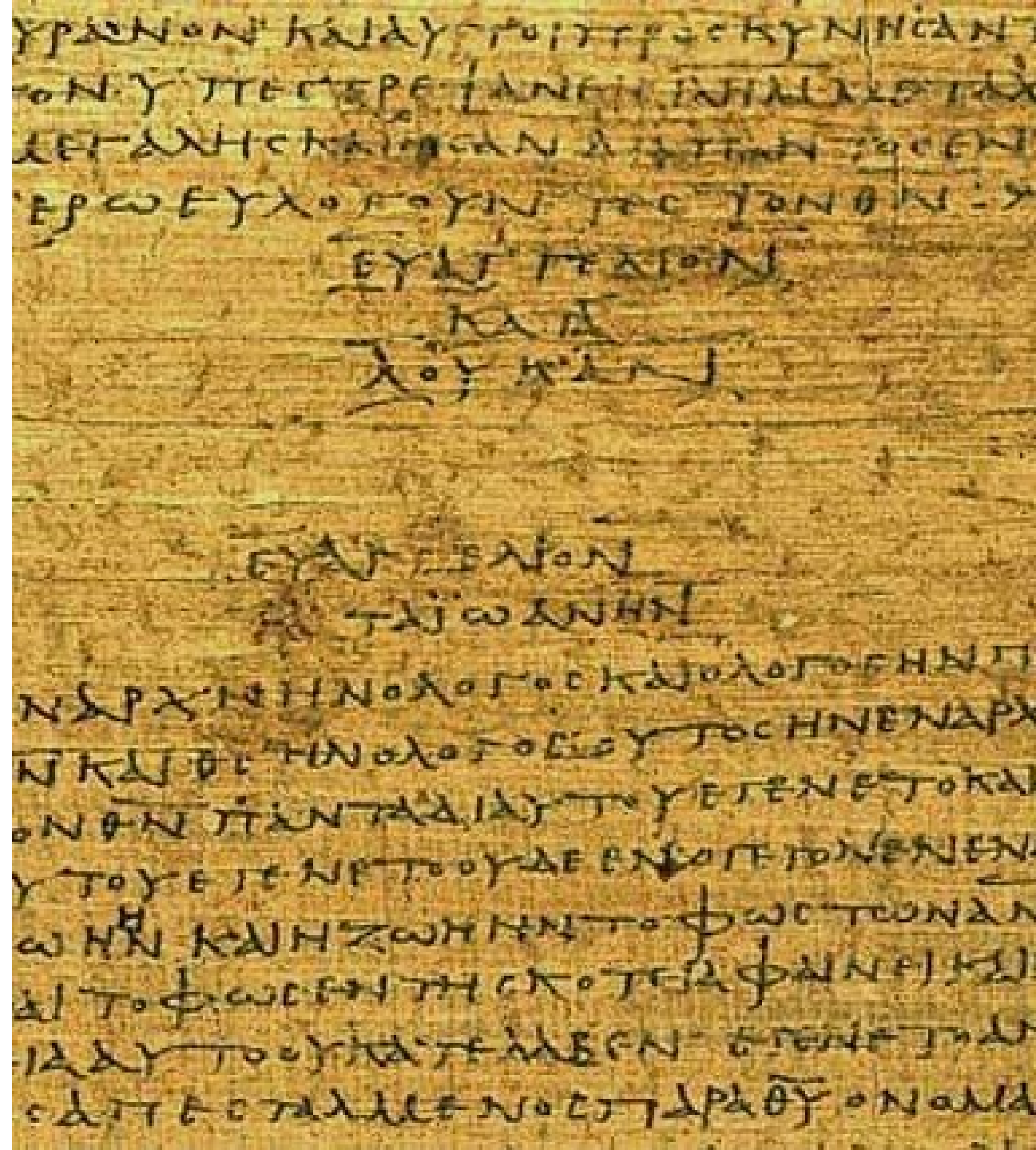


Sea vs seascape

- Seascapes can include sea, boats, marine life, coastal features and representation of the sea
- Abstract seascape is the concept of space and the cognitive link between the sea, land and the horizon
- Seascape a cultural construct
- Landscapes important in formation identity - seascape equally important for maritime identity
- Insights from Oceania and elsewhere, including Classical Aegean
- Important not to wholesale transplant into a different context

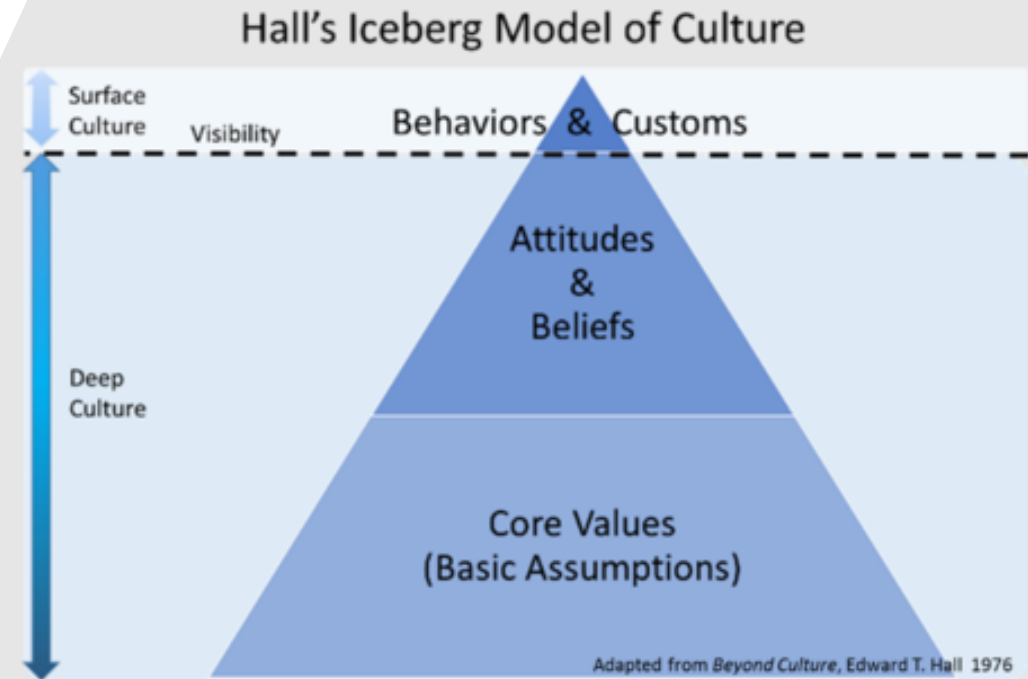
Text and seascapes

- The seascape perspective is informed by historical sources in Global archaeology
- Allow for an insight into the minds of the maritime communities
- No direct textual resources to investigate human relations with the sea in Aegean Bronze Age
- Linear A/B do not provide a full coverage of the issue and the Aegean



Culture

- Hall's "Iceberg model of culture"
- Three tiers to human culture,
- *Customs, beliefs* and *core values*
- Surface culture at the top, deep culture at the base.
- For surface culture the object is enough
- Seascape perspective aims to go beyond surface culture and investigate beliefs
- How is this possible without text?





Material engagement theory

- Analysis must focus heavily on *objects*
- The investigation of *beliefs* requires a more methodologically tight approach, focusing on the context and inter-relations in the archaeological record
- One such method is the introduction of **Material Engagement Theory (MET)**

Cognitive archaeology

- Cognitive archaeologists saw mind as encased in the cranium
- Interpretations saw past cognition beginning with an input into the brain and an output from the brain
- Mind imprisoned in the body
- **Passive human mind**





Problems and issues

“If people living by the sea interact with the sea, then they will depict it in their material culture. If they are not living beside the sea, then they will not depict it. People living in a coastal setting will have a closer connection to the sea, which will be expressed in material culture (and other, non-surviving forms)”

Coastal locations: Cyclades (3600 – 2000 BC)

- Does not play out in Cyclades
- Variable temporal importance of the seascape.
- Strongest expressions of maritime identity come in Early Bronze Age
- Contrasts with Middle Bronze Age - depopulation and defensible settlements
- Vibrant maritime imagery disappears with changes in the structure of Cycladic communities



Coastal locations: Crete (3000 BC – 1600 BC)

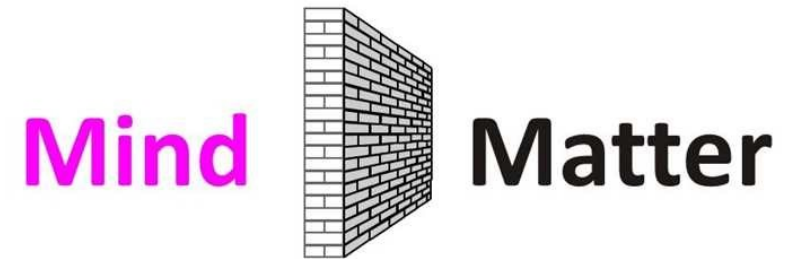
- Does not play out on Crete either – though reverse situation to the Cyclades
- Knossos – not coastal and for most of Bronze Age focuses on landscape in ritual (e.g. peak sanctuaries)
- This changes in the Late Bronze Age with introduction of maritime imagery in material culture
- Potentially a response to the Thera volcanic eruption



Breaking Cartesian duality

- MET rejects the mind as distinct from body
- Thought is not located just in the brain, but in coordination between the body and mind in action.
- Deconstruction of Cartesian duality between mind and body,
- Raises the possibility that material culture can be part of the “extended human mind”

Cartesian Dualism

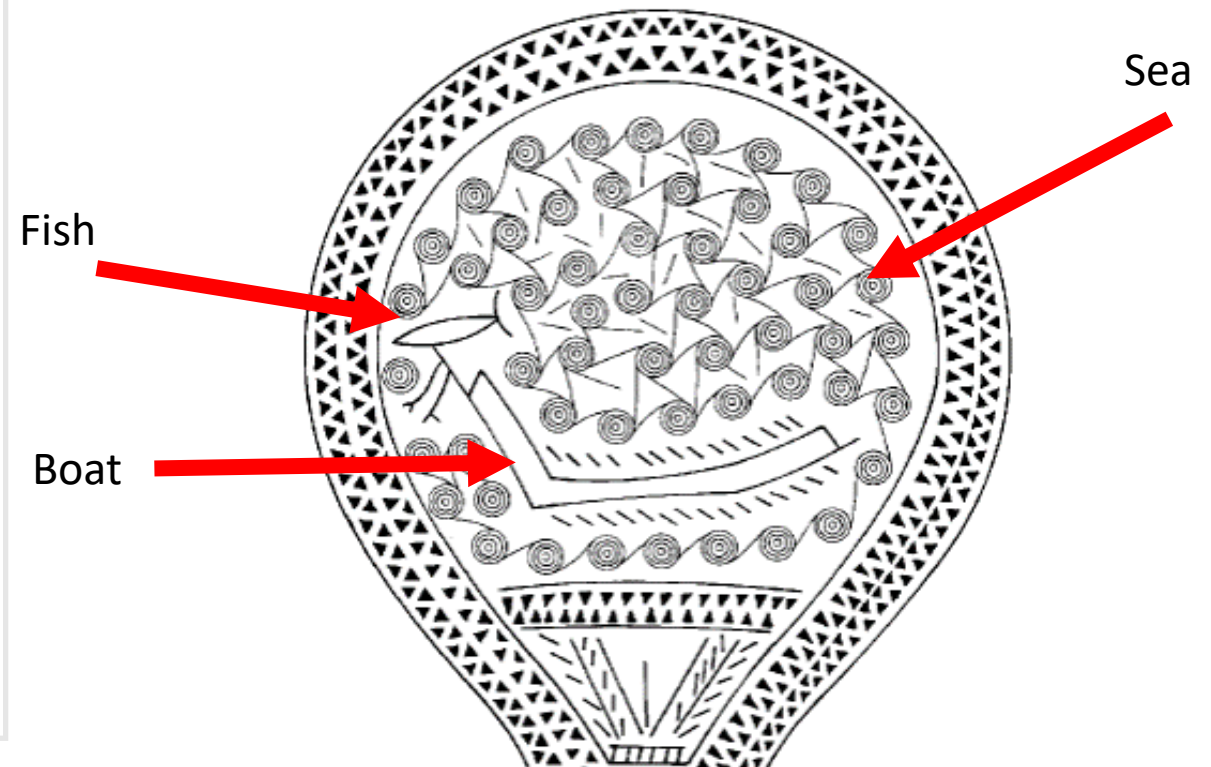


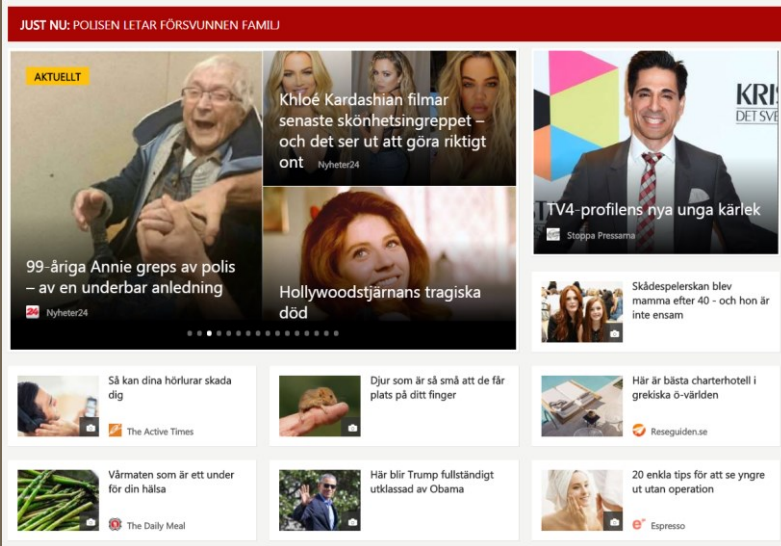
How can these perspectives
help in investigating past
interaction with Aegean
seascapes?



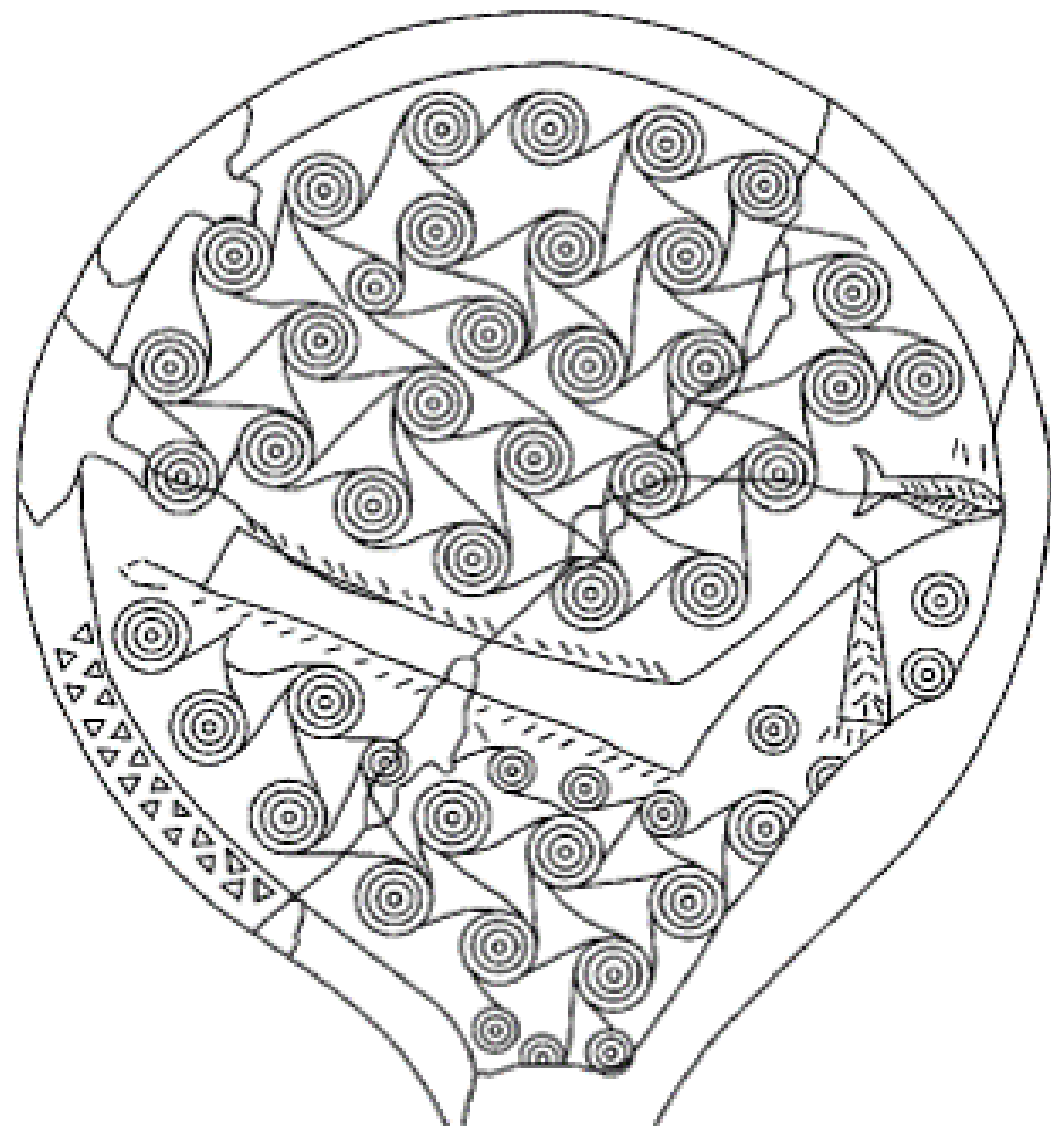
Material culture and representation

- Material culture part of the extended human mind of maritime communities
- Representation of the seascape can be used like text, though not as text
- In MET it is not “what does a symbol mean” but “when does it mean”
- Representation cannot be decoded but can point towards cultural trends





Modern exposure to images...

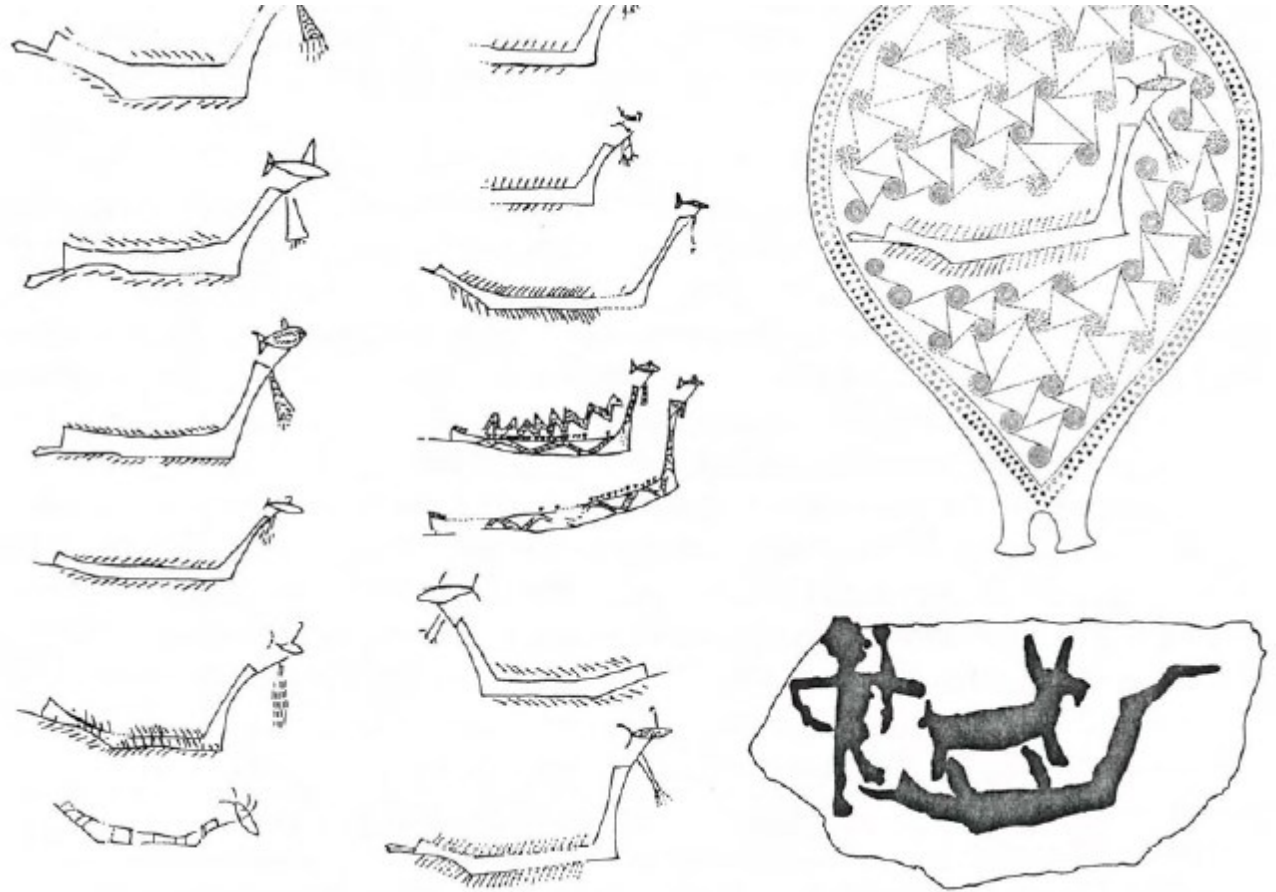


Questions

- When are certain types of images important and why?
- Why does it then change?
- With representation, as with text, we can read between the lines

Early Bronze Age (EBA) Cyclades (3600 – 2500 BC)

- Flourishing of sea related motifs such as boats, fish and spirals.
- Coincides expansion of a sea network, in which the Cycladic settlements played a key role.
- Seascape is significant in the Early Bronze Age





Early Bronze Age (EBA) Cyclades

- Found mostly in tomb contexts
- Seascape was important to the social identity of some individuals
- Not buried with everyone, may suggest tokens of power for groups linked to the seascape

Cycladic Dead?

- Burial of seascape related material culture significant in the funerary ritual
- Dozens of cemeteries in EBA = complete absence in Early Bronze-Middle Bronze Age
- People still occupied the Cyclades - where were people buried?
- Extensive archaeological survey find no cemeteries from this period.
- People buried at sea?
- Mortuary links to the seascape though material culture in EBA, later may have been through deposition of the body in the sea = transformation



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Middle Bronze Age (MBA/ Late Bronze Age (LBA) Cyclades (2500 – 1600 BC)

- Nucleation in the MBA in areas with good harbourage.
- Seascape representation in ceramics and frescoes
- Overall impression is that the Cycladic relationship with the sea has shifted
- Seascape loses its value as a base for identity, though maintains its importance through other means, as a bridge for contact e.g. Minoans, Mycenaeans in LBA
- Control of the seascape at a settlement level – less open to everyone?

Text vs Object Summary

- Material Engagement theory
- Seascape perspective
- Construction of text through objects and theory
- Complex relationship of Aegean Bronze Age communities with the seascape
- Not homogeneous or static throughout time
- Text + object pathways into the past human mind





Thank you for
your time, any
questions?